The Boys Next Door

By Tom Griffin

(Barry and Mr. Hedges on the grounds of the apartment complex. A bench. Bright sun. Barry is twenty-eight. He is full of positive conviction.)

BARRY: I'll tell you one of the basic problems of gold. Maybe the basic problem of golf. Gold is a game. It's just a game, Mr. Hodges, just a game.

MR. HEDGES: Hedges.

BARRY: It's too early to worry about that. Besides, I don't know of more than two or three courses with a serious hedge hazard. Sure, traps. Sure, thick rough. Sure. But hedges. That's rare.

MR. HEDGES: My name is Hedges. My Name is John Hedges.

BARRY: I have no reason to doubt that. But you're paying good money for this lesson, and we can't spend all the time worrying about the occasional hedge. It just doesn't make senses.

MR. HEDGES: Are you joking?

BARRY: I don't joke, John. *(Pause).* Today, our first lesson we're not even going to touch a club. Today's lesson, I call, "How to Handle a Heckler in the Gallery."

MR. HEDGES: Gallery? What gallery? I play on a nine hole public course. I just want a few basic tips. Maybe we should just forget this whole thing. It doesn't seem to be working out.

BARRY: Don't quit now, John. Hang in there. I know that the first lesson is difficult, but it'll get easier. I promise you. There'll be a lot less to memorize as we go along.

MR. HEDGES: *(Coldly)* What's the tip?

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BARRY: Okay. Let me think. There are so many. Ah, here's one that I think can be quite useful. At the top of your backswing, come to a complete stop, the club parallel to the ground, and take a moment to reflect on how fortunate we are to live in a time when golf is in full flower. Then hit that little round sucker as viciously as you can!

(SCENE)

BARRY: *(to audience)* I couldn't begin to figure it. He just quit. Hodges quit. He was obsessed with Hedges. He walked away screaming at me, "Hedges! Hedges! Hedges!" Now I'm down to two students. At one dollar and thirteen cents per student, each student would have to take forty hours of instruction each week just for me to get ninety dollars and forty cents. I computed it. That's before expenses *(Dawns on him)* I still have to buy clubs yet.

INTRODUCTION

Barry Klemper . . . self-proclaimed golf-pro, but don't get too invested in that description. Barry suffers from schizophrenia and has lived most of his life in an institution. Now at age 28, he has moved into a supervised group home with other handicapped and mentally ill young men. He spends his days recruiting golf-students who are excited about his extremely low rates at first . . . but then, like Mr. Hedges, they discover the reason why. In this selection, you'll learn there is much more to Barry than meets the eye – You'll discover his past, his family and possibly begin to understand why Barry struggles to relate to a father whom he wants to idolize, but simply cannot. The Boys Next Door by Tom Griffin

BARRY: A letter? *(After a pause, affected)* It's from my Dad. He's coming to visit me. He's going to be in Boston for a day and he's coming down to visit me. *(Barry is shaken by the letter – Trancelike)* It's from Dad . . . My Dad. . . Dad is coming to visit me . . . Do you know what Dad does? He coaches third base for the New York Yankees. Kipper Klemper is what they call him. [He] used to be a backfield coach with the San Francisco Forty-niners. He know all the guys. All the guys

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knew him. . . . I haven't seen him in nine years. . . . You know, he's been busy. You know, on the road. But every Christmas, no matter what, he sends me a box of chocolates. Whether he's busy of not. Every Christmas. Oh, a couple of times, you know, the box arrived late, but he never forgets. Not my Dad! . . . Did you know that my Dad once played one on one with Bob Cousy and ate him up. Just ate Cousey right up. *(On the edge)* A hook shot here, a driving layup there. Defense! Defense! Defense! . . . Can I tell you something personal? I mean, just between you and me? A secret? . . . My Dad scares me. He scares me something terrible. Something terrible. . . If I had lots of money, I'd got to Florida now Really. I'd go down there, play a few rounds every day, ie on the beach and listen to the radio, maybe even bring a thermos full of highballs. Maybe even take my dad. Yeah, I'd take Dad. *(Pause)* In just two days, he'll be here. Of course, he'll probably look older. People look older. That's just the aging process. *(Starkly)* My dad, you know, when Mom died, he was pretty busy with his career. So when he brought me out to the Institutions, he couldn't stay around too long. He kind of waves. *(Barry cannot continue. He is very disturbed. Pause).* Every Christmas, no matter what, those chocolates came. But, and I guess Dad just forgot this, but I never really like chocolate very much. I'd get stomachaches from it, you know. (*Barry breaks down and sobs)*

TRANSITION

And soon the day arrives . . . Barry's father arrives at the group home for the first visit with his son in over 9 years – Is Barry's hero-worship of his father justified, or simply a product of his schizophrenic illness? I'll let you decide . . . .

MR. KLEMPER: These goddam apartment zoos are all like a maze. Built for goddamn rats. Wouldn't live in one of these sties for all the tea in goddam China. *(Seeing Barry, stopped cold)* So this is my little Barry. Grown up real good. Real good. A . . . real man. Real good *(Pause) (Tossing a bag in Barry's lap)*

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Got you this. It's just a little something. *(Sees the sign)* You do this, Barry? It's real nice. "Welcome, Home, Dad!" Real thoughtful. So, why don't you open it up? *(No response)*

BARRY: Hello. My name is Barry Klemper. Welcome to my home. Won't you take a seat?

MR. KLEMPER: I think I'll stand. Those buses put the seats so close together it's a goddamn wonder I don't have a hernia. But thanks for the offer. *(gesturing to the bag as Barry begins to open it)* It's nothing. Just a little something. Nothing. *(Barry reaches in the bag and pulls out a cheap boxed heart. The heart is visible through cellophane. It is broken)*

BARRY: *(By rote)* Thank you very much. I appreciate it. Thank you.

MR. KLEMPER: Like I said, it's just a thought. You can take that cellophane off if you want to. They just put it on to keep it fresh.

BARRY: Thank you very much. I appreciate it. Thank you.

MR. KLEMPER: *(Nervous loud stream of consciousness.)* My scheme was to get you a bos, you know, like always. A nice box of Fanny Farmer, something like that. One of those boxes where inside they got a cherry wrapped up fancy in tinfoil. But I was kind of in a rush, so I had to pick it up at the bus station. They got a gift shop at the bus station. Gifts, cigarettes, gum. Anyway, they didn't have any chocolates. I asked. But then the lady said they had this. This chocolate heart. Well, right way I could see that the goddamn thing was all broken into pieces. "It's damaged," I told the lady. "It's been here since Valentine's Day," she said. "The goddamn thing is damaged," I told her. They get sassy with me, I get sassy right back. They think, a one-armed man, he won't be sassy. Well, bullshit to that. So I said to her, "I'll give you half price." And get this? The old sow said yes. *(Silence. Barry is still. Mr. Klemper paces uncomfortably)*. . . . Yeah,

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it's real nice here, Barry. A nice setup. I heard your roommate was a darkie *(Pause)* So what have you been doing with yourself?

BARRY: Won't you take a seat?

MR. KLEMPER: I'll stand *(Long pause)* So what have you got to say for yourself, boy? *(Silence. Mr. Klemper is getting progressively more frustrated)* Your mother, God rest her pathetic soul, used to worry that you'd never talk. It wasn't until you were about three that you said your first word. You know what that word was? "Bitch." Your mother and me, we thought that was about the funniest thing we ever heard. We took you right over to Auntie Mae's house so she could hear it. And you said it again, "Bitch." Clear as a bell. We were real proud of you, boy. Real Proud. "Bitch." I'll never forget it. *(Stops)* Are you going to talk, boy, or are you going to keep it up with this silent crap? *(No response).* I'm talking to you, you little sonovabitch! I'm your goddamn father. When your goddamn father talks, you better goddamn listen. *(Nothing).* You hear me boy? This is your father, not some goddamn darkie roommate. This is your father! You hear me boy? You goddamn nut!! *(Mr. Klemper, impulsively, violently, slaps Barry across the side of the head. Barry recoils, then instinctively draws into a fetal position on the couch. Mr. Kelmper backs off, shocked by his own violence. Barry protects himself and moans)*

BARRY: No, Dad! No more, Dad. Please, Dad. No more . . . . Don't hit me anymore! Please, Dad . . .

MR. KLEMPER: No, no I'm sorry. I . . . lost control. Jesus, Barry, I didn't mean to . . . I'm sorry, I . . .

BARRY: *(Whimpering)* No, Dad. Please, Dad. Don't hit me . . . Please. . .

MR. KLEMPER: *(Paralyzed)* It was . . . .It was an accident, Barry. I didn't mean to. I just . . . you know . . . lost control. I'm sorry. Jesus . . . . *(Barry stops*

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whimpering. Warily, he rights himself. There is nothing or either of them to say. Mr. Klemper starts for the door). Well, I . . . guess I'd better go. Those buses, they run right on time. Buses don't wait for a one-armed man. That's one thing I've learned in life, Barry. Buses don't wait for a one-armed man. *(Pause)* And don't you worry, boy. Christmas comes around, those chocolates will be in the mail. Count on it. (Pause) It ain't my way, Barry, but your mother, God rest her pathetic soul, would want you to know that when you were just a little baby who couldn't talk or nothing, she loved you more than life itself. More than goddamned life itself. *(Mr. Kemper exits. Barry calls weakly to the closed door)*

BARRY: Dad. Dad, I'm a golf pro now, Dad.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2004 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
AR State Finalist
Utah State Finalist

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